

Designing the Invisible

Concepting Wearable Investing for Apple Watch’s First Day

TEAM / ROLE

Experience
Design Lead

**Concept &
Visual Designer**

WatchOS
Engineer

Rotating Support:
Design, IA, PM, QA

COMPANY



Context & Opportunity

The Situation

In 2014, there were whisperings of an Apple Watch release. No dev tools, specs, or interaction patterns were available, but it was clear this would change how people interacted with technology. Fidelity saw a chance to define what financial confidence could feel like in a new format.

Design Challenge:

With no screen specs or patterns to lean on, we had to define what should fit and what mattered most in two seconds or less.

Actions Taken in my role

- Contributed to early concepting before WatchKit release
- Developed a concept to provoke conversation and expand the vision
- Returned during implementation to shape the final glance views and complications



A 3D-printed watch working off the crumbs of specs shared ahead of the initial announcement. Leveraged to test physical world renderings of digital designs.

Understanding the User



User Lens: The Tech-Savvy Active Investor

We didn't conduct formal interviews given the timeline, but we knew this early watch release would attract a specific persona:

- Comfortable with emerging tech and quick to adopt new tools
- Engages with the market frequently, not just a passive investor.
- Likely juggling multiple accounts and information sources

Behavioral Assumptions

- Checks market status multiple times a day
- Wants quick confidence, not a full transaction journey on the Watch

Sources That Informed This

- Internal Fidelity personas from mobile and trading research
- Observed app engagement behaviors across platforms

Exploring Watches Through Time

Framing the Wrist

Desk research on the cultural and emotional role of watches across time:

- 1800s Pocket Watches: Personal control in a world without universal time
Glancing = reassurance
- 1970s–80s Digital Watches: Performance surface for the tech-forward
Wrist = data identity
- 2000s Fitness Bands: Micro-achievements & nudges
Wrist = behavioral coaching
- Apple Watch (Speculation Era): Notification triage
Wrist = filter, not feed

Opposite: Watch exploration across as many analog/digital designs. Taking a breadth wrist experiences to inform concepting.

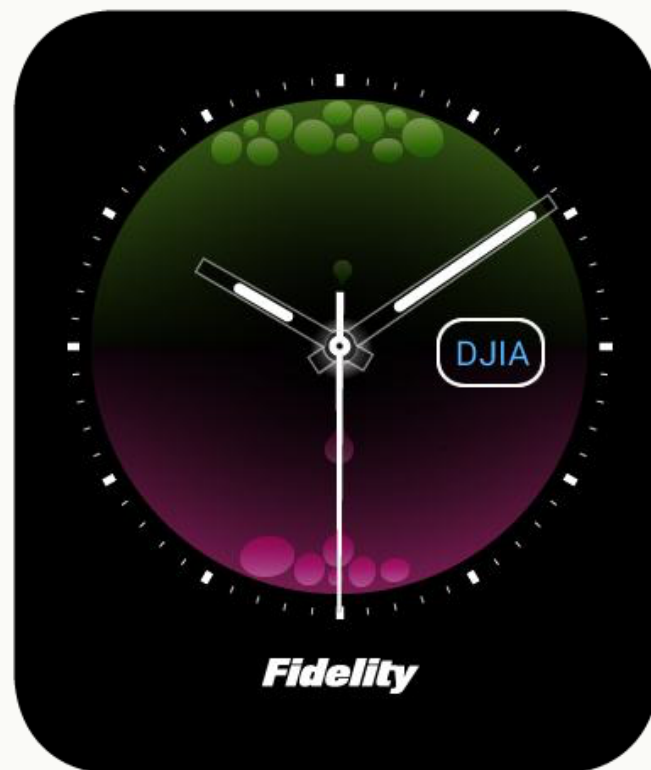


Concept Development



Hour by Hour

Communicating market health across open hours



Lava Lamp

Ambient bubble mood indicator selected



Timeline

Rippling market trend tracker



Radar Pulse

Volatility signal through subtle pulse



Guiding Principles

Grounded in user behavior assumptions and cultural watch signals, these principles framed how we approached early concept exploration.



Glanceable first

Based on how people physically use their wrists and expect value from a glance. A quick look of ~2 seconds should be enough to feel informed.



Emotional clarity

Designs must calm, particularly when the market is volatile.



Signal, not noise

Designed to minimize mental effort by filtering out distractions and surfacing what matters most.



Always additive

The Watch isn't a standalone tool, it's a trust-building extension of the broader Fidelity experience.

Impact & Reflection

Reception & Influence

- Concept didn't ship, but sparked excitement internally and with Apple's team and opened up a partnership opportunity as we developed the official Fidelity Watch App
- Helped Fidelity establish credibility as a forward-thinking design org at a critical tech inflection point.

Strategic Impact

- Launched on Day 1 of Apple Watch release and became one of the first financial services apps available on the platform
- App Store average rating: 4.8 stars
- Sparked future wearable/ambient experiments
- Helped solidify Fidelity's platform credibility with Apple

Looking Back

This project taught me how to:

- Create clarity in ambiguous situations before specs exist
- Contribute direction even without owning delivery

If I were tackling this again today, I'd bring earlier user testing and motion prototyping into the concept phase, even informal, lightweight interviews or motion studies to test how glance behavior and emotional tone landed with real users.

Fidelity Mobile Team Contributions

In addition to the Apple Watch concept, I supported Fidelity's mobile team for 7+ years, steering key innovations across authentication, media, convenience, and personalization.

Security & Trust Builders

- Rolled out biometric + two-factor authentication, elevating user confidence in secure access.
- Co-designed the Fidelity Feed to spark engagement, build confidence, and help younger investors explore beyond transactions.

Convenience & Independence

- Designed the mobile check deposit experience, enabling customers to deposit from anywhere not just in branch.
- Led Alerts & Watchlist Notebook features, empowering quick tracking and easier monitoring.

Platform & Emerging Tech

- Explored early Voice/Chat Assistant and Echo Show integrations positioning Fidelity ahead in alternative access points.
- Designed mobile news & video UX, and reimagined experiences for platform-specific iOS/Android constraints.
- Maintained a component library to ensure alignment between design and engineering as new features launched.

Learnings from the mobile space.

Designing across many surfaces, teams, and problems at Fidelity shaped how I think and lead.

- Learned how to build trust with users not just through features, but through consistency, clarity, and tone.
- Built fluency in balancing platform constraints with brand goals navigating iOS, Android, and emerging tech like wearables, and voice.
- Saw how ideas live or die by how clearly they're communicated and how sketches, stories, and principles can shape direction in the fog.
- Built confidence in knowing when to explore, when to refine, and when to ship.

These projects helped me grow as a design partner who can operate at both altitude and detail, bring focus to ambiguity, and build systems that make users feel more confident and capable.

Thank you!